

Hansoh Pharma (3692.HK): Continued BD execution; Out-licensed oral IL-23 through a NewCo-and-Merger structure

Licensing-out an oral IL-23 to NewCo Avere, with planned Nasdaq listing through merger:

Hansoh announced an exclusive ex-Greater China licensing agreement with Avere Therapeutics for HS-20118 (AVR-001), a once-weekly oral IL-23 receptor antagonist, for US\$120mn upfront, up to US\$2.18bn in development and commercial milestones, and mid-single to low-double digit royalties on future sales outside Greater China. The transaction is centered around Avere, a NewCo established in 2025 by Hansoh together with a group of financial investors. In parallel with the licensing transaction, Avere completed a US\$320mn private financing led by Fairmount and Hansoh, with participation from a broad syndicate of crossover and specialist biotech investors, and subsequently entered into an agreement to merge with Nasdaq-listed NextCure in an all-stock transaction. Unlike many recent China biotech NewCo transactions that utilize cash shells, NextCure is an operating biotech with its own oncology pipeline, including CDH6 and B7-H4 ADC programs. Upon completion of the merger, Hansoh is expected to hold a 30-40% equity stake in the combined company, enabling the company to retain meaningful exposure to future value creation for HS-20118. Given Hansoh's expected ownership position, we would expect potential regulatory review considerations, such as CFIUS, although the scope, timing and outcome of any such review remain unclear. We view the transaction as another demonstration of Hansoh's continued BD execution. Management has previously communicated its target of 1-2 BD deals annually, and the company has delivered on this objective since 2023.

Oral IL-23 remains an attractive but competitive opportunity: According to the company announcement, HS-20118 demonstrated PASI and PASI75 responses broadly comparable to a first-generation once-daily oral IL-23 inhibitor (we believe to be J&J's icotrokinra) while offering once-weekly dosing supported by an approximately 100-hour half-life. While oral IL-23 remains an attractive concept given the convenience advantage versus injectable biologics, available Phase 3 psoriasis data suggest efficacy may still lag leading IL-23 and IL-17 biologics based on cross-trial comparisons. Icotrokinra reported PASI90 rates of **50%** at Week 16, compared with roughly **70-80%** historically reported by injectable IL-23 and IL-17 biologics in pivotal studies (see [Exhibit 1](#)). As such, we believe the commercial opportunity for oral IL-23 therapies will ultimately depend on whether they can offer a sufficiently attractive balance between efficacy, safety, convenience and pricing, rather than convenience alone. For HS-20118 specifically, the once-weekly dosing profile and long half-life may provide differentiation within the oral IL-23 category, but further clinical data will be required to establish its competitive positioning.

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Exhibit 1: Comparison of clinical data of IL-23 / IL-17 targeted drugs

Drug	Icotrokinra	Secukinumab	HS-20137	Guselkumab	Mirikizumab	Ixekizumab
Target	Oral IL-23	IL-17A mAb	IL-23 mAb	IL-23 mAb	IL-23 mAb	IL-17A mAb
Company	JNJ	Novartis	Hansoh / Qyuns	JNJ	Eli Lilly	Eli Lilly
Clinical trial						
Trials	NCT06095115	NCT02826603	ChiCTR2300075645	NCT03090100	NCT03482011	NCT01474512
Phase	Phase III	Phase III	Phase II	Phase III	Phase III	Phase III
Sample size	684	1,102	159	1,048	530	1,296
Control	Placebo	secukinumab 300 mg (n = 550) or ustekinumab 45/90 mg (n = 552)	Placebo	secukinumab	Placebo	Placebo
Dose	oral, QD		100/200mg Q8W, 200mg Q12W	guselkumab 100 mg Q8W vs secukinumab	250mg s.c. Q4W	80mg Q2W or Q4W s.c
Patient baseline						
Median age (year)	42.6	45.4	41-46	45.8	45.7-46.4	45 - 46
Race	White (72%), Asian (24%)	White (75.3%)	Chinese	White (93%), Asian (3%)		White (91.9%-93%)
Psoriasis duration (mean, year)	17.1			18.4	17.0 - 17.7	19 - 20
PASI score mean	20		24-29	20	22.3 - 23.5	20 - 21
Bioexperienced	34%	-	-	29%		
Efficacy data						
Assessment time	Week 16	Week 12 / 16	Week 16	Week 12/48	Week 16	Week 12
PASI response						
- PASI75 (%)	69% vs 11%	88.0% (week 12); 91.7% (week 16)	92.3% (200mg Q8W)	89% vs 92% (week 12)	82.5% vs 9.3%	89.1% vs 3.9% (Q2W)
- PASI90 (%)	50% vs 4%	76.6% (week 16)	76.9% (200mg Q8W) vs 7.5% (pbo)	69% vs 76% (week 12)	64.3% vs 6.5%	70.9% vs 0.5% (Q2W)
- PASI100 (%)	27% vs <1%	38.1% (week 12); 45.3% (week 16)	40% (200mg Q12W)	58% vs 48% (week 48)	32.4% vs 0.9%	35.3% vs 0% (Q2W)
PGA response						
- Minimal or cleared (%)	65% vs 8%				69.3% vs 6.5%	81.8% vs 3.2% (Q2W)
- ss-PGA0/1 (scalp)	72% vs 15%					
Safety data						
AEs	49% vs 49%	47.5%	71.8% (200mg Q8W) vs 70% (pbo)		47.4% vs 47.7%	58.4% vs 46.8%
Serious AEs	1% vs 3%	2.5%	7.7% (200mg Q8W) vs 0% (pbo)	6% vs 7%	1.2% vs 1.9%	1.7% vs 1.5%
AE leading to withdrawal	1% vs <1%			2% vs 2%	0.7% vs 0.9%	2.1% vs 1.1%

Source: NEJM, AAD 2025, British Journal of Dermatology

Exhibit 2: HS-20118's once-weekly dosing profile may provide differentiation

Landscape of oral IL-23 and IL-17 drugs in plaque psoriasis

Molecule	Target	Modality	Company	Stage	Dose interval
icotrokinra	IL-23R	peptide	J&J / Protagonist	Approved	QD
HSK47388	IL-23	peptide	Haisco	Phase 2	QD
simepdekinra	IL-17	small molecule	DICE Therapeutics	Phase 2	n.a.
HS-20118	IL-23R	peptide	Hansoh / Avere	Phase 2	QW
UA026	IL-17A	small molecule	Usynova	Phase 1	n.a.
ZB021	IL-17A / IL-17F	small molecule	InnoCare / Zenas	Phase 1	QD or BID
ASC50	IL-17A	small molecule	Ascletis	Phase 1	QD or QW
PN-881	IL-17A / IL-17F	peptide	Protagonist	Phase 1	QD or BID

Source: Pharmcube

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Hansoh Pharma

Valuation methodology: We are Buy rated on Hansoh Pharma with a 12-m TP of HK\$50.10. Our TP is based on a SOTP, comprised of 1) a DCF of HK\$281.4bn for innovative drugs; and 2) a valuation of HK\$21.9bn for generics, with a FY26 P/E of 10x.

3692.HK	12m Price Target: HK\$50.10	Price: HK\$32.56	Upside: 53.9%
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Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 14 Jul 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

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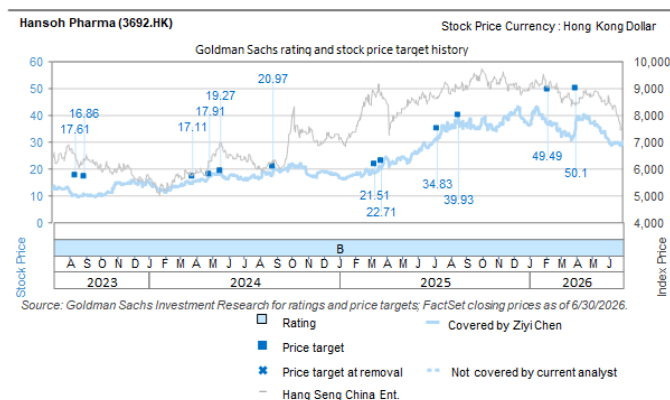
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Hansoh Pharma (3692.HK)

Date of report Target price (HK\$) Closing price (HK\$)

01-Apr-26	50.10	37.42
05-Feb-26	49.49	36.62
18-Aug-25	39.93	37.06
08-Jul-25	34.83	30.65
23-Mar-25	22.71	20.10
11-Mar-25	21.51	18.80
28-Aug-24	20.97	20.60
19-May-24	19.27	18.24
29-Apr-24	17.91	17.48
26-Mar-24	17.11	14.88
05-Oct-23	16.86	10.06
31-Aug-23	16.86	10.20
13-Aug-23	17.61	10.26

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